

Fall 2026 weekday bus requirement: fleet certification

To: MBTA Board of Directors From: Service Planning, schedule certification Date: 5 October 2026

Certified requirement

The Board should certify the Fall 2026 weekday bus requirement at **621 buses**, +6 against the Summer 2026 certification of 615. The peak falls in the morning, at 07:51, when 621 buses are in service at once; the Summer peak fell at 07:50. The same files reproduce the Summer certification of 615 exactly, so the two figures are on one basis. Finance's draft peak of 521 is not certified. The schedule behind the fleet change is a net +149 weekday trips, 12,893 to 13,042, and **Route 65** (Brighton Center - Kenmore Station) is the single route behind the biggest share of it at +45 trips; Finance's +321 and the planners' +121 are not certified.

What the other figures counted, and why they are not certified

Finance's peak of 521 buses. It is the most trips underway at one moment, which happens at 17:26 in the afternoon peak (the Summer equivalent is 513 at 17:26). A trip is not a bus. Between consecutive trips a bus sits at a terminal on layover and is still in service and still assigned, so the count of trips underway runs about a hundred below the count of buses out, and it peaks in the afternoon when trips are long rather than in the morning when the most buses are out. Counting each bus from its first departure to its last arrival gives 615 for Summer, which matches the certification, and 621 for Fall.

Finance's +321 weekday trips. It compares the first weekday schedule in the feed published as Fall 2026 (Monday 24 August, 12,721 trips) with the Fall count of 13,042. That August weekday is still the Summer rating on a no school day. The Summer rating switches to its school day weekday on 31 August, at 12,893 trips, and the Fall rating begins on 6 September, so the like for like change is +149.

The planners' +121. It counts each route's timetable as published, which lists a trip under every route it serves, so a trip on a combined route is counted two or three times: 13,128 and 13,249 instead of 12,893 and 13,042. Counting every trip once, under its own route, gives +149.

How the certified figures were built

The archive index assigns the feed published 21 August 2026 to every date from 21 August onward, so both comparison days come from that feed, and the Summer day was re-run on the feed published 12 August with an identical result. The Summer day is Wednesday 2 September 2026 and the Fall day is Wednesday 23 September 2026, both Monday to Thursday school days on which every active service is flagged typical. Trips were taken from the services active on each date rather than from the rating label on the service, because long running services labelled Spring/Summer continue under the Fall rating. The route population is every route the feed classifies as Frequent, Local, Coverage, Commuter, or Supplemental Bus; rail replacement shuttles are excluded and none ran on either day. Each trip was counted once under its own route. For the fleet figure every trip was assigned to its block, each block was treated as one bus in service from its first departure to its last arrival, and the number of blocks in service was counted at every minute of the service day. The count is identical on every other qualifying day in each rating.

Buses in service through the day

The hour that gained the most buses is the **22:00 hour**, +16 (233 to 249). The growth sits in the evening and late night rather than at the peak: the morning peak gains 6, while every hour from 19:00 onward gains between 2 and 16 buses. The full hourly profile is in weekday_bus_requirement.csv and bus_requirement_profile.png.

Routes whose weekday trip count changed, ranked by size of change

Rank	Route	Category	Summer	Fall	Change
1	65	Local Bus	86	131	+45
2	465	Local Bus	0	32	+32
3	70	Local Bus	147	172	+25
4	222	Local Bus	62	83	+21
5	220	Local Bus	62	81	+19
6	66	Frequent Bus	232	247	+15
7	26	Local Bus	82	72	-10

Rank	Route	Category	Summer	Fall	Change
8	SLW	Frequent Bus	61	53	-8
9	16	Local Bus	208	215	+7
10	34	Local Bus	98	92	-6
11	504	Commuter Bus	72	66	-6
12	35	Local Bus	70	73	+3
13	435	Local Bus	35	38	+3
14	7	Local Bus	147	149	+2
15	24	Local Bus	67	65	-2
16	28	Frequent Bus	204	206	+2
17	32	Frequent Bus	300	302	+2
18	34E	Local Bus	78	80	+2
19	41	Local Bus	49	51	+2
20	44	Local Bus	102	100	-2
21	116	Frequent Bus	253	255	+2
22	216	Local Bus	145	147	+2
23	553	Local Bus	40	38	-2
24	9	Frequent Bus	204	205	+1
25	10	Local Bus	85	84	-1
26	39	Frequent Bus	230	229	-1
27	77	Frequent Bus	188	189	+1
28	436	Local Bus	32	33	+1
All bus routes 152 routes			12,893	13,042	+149

The other 124 bus routes run the same number of weekday trips under both ratings, and the 28 changes sum to +149.

Route 65: what changed

Under the Summer rating 23 buses carry Route 65 trips during the weekday; under the Fall rating 33 do. Summer service ran 86 trips with the first departure at 05:58 and the last arrival at 21:03; Fall runs 131 trips from 05:00 to 25:33 (01:33 the next morning). The route was extended at its inbound end: Summer inbound trips end at Kenmore (headsign Kenmore) and Fall inbound trips end at Ruggles (headsign Ruggles), with the span opening about an hour earlier and closing more than four hours later. The added trips come from the longer span and more frequent service through the day, not from the Brighton Center end.

How close the driving route is to being overtaken

Route 465 (Danvers Square - Salem Depot via Liberty Tree Mall) is the runner-up at +32, 13 trips behind. The smallest change in a single route's Fall trip count that would make a different route the driver is **14 trips**: Route 465 at 46 Fall trips (+46), or Route 65 at 117 (+31). The third largest change is +25 on Route 70.

Why no other figure survives

The Board's convention fixes the day type, the day of week band, the population, and the unit: a bus from its first departure to its last arrival. The feed fixes which services run on each date and which trips share a bus. Applied together they give one Summer profile and one Fall profile, stable across every qualifying day and identical in both archived feeds, and the Summer profile returns the certified 615 exactly. Every other figure relaxes one fixed point: trips underway instead of buses out, a no school day, a timetable listing instead of a trip, or a rating label instead of a date. 621 buses, +6, is the only requirement the convention and the files allow.